



EVEN TODAY WITH AN ELECTED GOVERNMENT, the Ashanti people

ASHANTI

A ROYAL TRADITION OF CRAFTWORK

of southern Ghana continue to place great importance on their king, who is known as the *asantehene*. Royal patronage enabled the arts to flourish

The cloth of kings

Graphically patterned *Kente* cloth has been worn by Ashanti royalty since the 12th century. Because every pattern has a name, often inspired by a famous person, event, or proverb, *kente* cloth is much more than fabric. It is the bearer of Ashanti history, culture, and beliefs.



1 Dyeing yarn

The yarn is boiled together with starch and dye in a large kettle heated over a fire pit. Then it is hung out to dry under the hot Ghanaian sun.



2 Big bobbins

Bobbo, a master weaver, winds the dry yarn onto enormous bobbins. He chooses a design and selects his colors before he sets up the loom and starts weaving.



3 Little bobbins

After school, Bobbo's son winds yarn and learns to weave by helping his father, as Bobbo did before him.

AT THE LOOM

Kente cloth is woven out of doors. A loom with very long warp threads is used so that long, thin strips of fabric are produced. The weaver opens and closes these using a lever controlled by his feet. At the same time, he throws the shuttle holding the weft threads rapidly back and forth between the warp threads.

The wooden loom is built and maintained by the weaver.



CORONATION PROCESSION

A spectacular procession takes place when a new *asantehene* (king) comes to power. It features the Golden Stool, which is believed to have descended from heaven in the 17th century. The *asantehene* may not actually sit on it but he is lowered and raised three times over this symbol of Ashanti power. At his enstoolment, as on all state occasions, he wears gold jewelry and a type of *kente* cloth that is reserved only for kings.



THE FINAL STAGE

The long strips of fabric are sewn together to make the actual cloth. A man's robe requires 24 strips on average, while a woman's skirt needs far fewer.